would carry the number 29,002 feet! [6] Later measurements show the exact height at 29,029 feet or 8848 metres above sea level.

Now came the issue of naming Peak XV. The Tibetans already called it Chomolungma (Mother Goddess of the World). Unusually for the colonial period, the Survey of India tended to retain the local names where possible but in this case the temptation proved too great. It was named after George Everest. Like many people today, I used to wonder why the British would name the highest mountain in the world after the Surveyor General of India rather than after royalty or even a Viceroy. However, having read about the sheer scale of the Great Trigonometrical Survey of India, I can see that it was not so odd after all.

THE REVOLT OF 1857

By the time Mount Everest was being named, the British were very much in control of the whole subcontinent. What was not directly ruled by the British was managed through one-sided treaties with the remaining local princes. Not since the Mauryas had such a large part of the subcontinent been controlled by a single power. How did the British succeed where earlier European powers had failed? Technological advantage was important, but cannot have been the deciding factor. Unlike in the Americas, Africa or Australia, the technological gap between the Europeans and the locals was not so large as to be able to neutralize a very large numerical superiority. In many instances, there were European mercenaries and allies fighting on the Indian side. Yet, the British were repeatedly able to beat off much larger armies and then maintain control with a tiny number of officials. Why?

What is most striking about the British conquest of India is that so few British were involved. The armies of the East India Company were largely made up of Indian sepoys. Moreover, in many cases, the British received encouragement and support from the locals. For instance, at the Battle of Plassey, Robert Clive was funded and encouraged by the merchants of Bengal. Some historians tend to see this as proof that Indians did not have